

Text: Excerpt from the article

'I feel I've come home': can forest schools help heal refugee children?

By Patrick Barkham



Setting off on a tracking hunt.

Photograph: Wild Things

When Kate Milman was 21, she paused her English degree at the University of East Anglia to join protests against the Newbury bypass. It was 1996, and the road was being carved out through idyllic wooded countryside in Berkshire. She took up residence in a treehouse, in the path of the bulldozers, and lived there for months. It was a revelation. She lived intimately with the catkins¹, the calling birds, the slow-slow-fast change in the seasons. Despite being in a precarious position as a protester, she felt completely safe and her brain was calmed. [...]

Finally, however, she was evicted from her forest heartland. The men and their machines arrived beneath her tree. Kate was arrested under a newly created "aggravated trespass"² law and barred from joining the protests again. The wood was ripped apart.

"That level of grief – it felt like losing somebody," Kate says now. It was a highly complex woodland and she had come to know it intimately. "I knew how beautiful it was at dawn and at full moon, and then it was bulldozed. When you watch that amount of stupidity, when you have that much grief and impotence, what can you do with it?"

The idea for Wild Things, a workers' cooperative set up to provide children with experience of the natural world, was born. For three days each week, she and her fellow co-op members, Kath, Kat and Nick (her partner), provide half-day sessions for groups of nine pupils from various city schools.

I've come to a Wild Things day at Bestwood Country Park, a hilltop woodland on the edge of Nottingham. The wind runs through the canopy in waves, worrying the leaves, but it is calm and snug in the green, brambly understorey. The slender trunks of silver birches shine in the low sunlight. [...]

The children we're with today are mostly 10-year-olds, members of an "English as a second language" group from Forest Fields primary and nursery school. The school's bucolic³ name belies its location in central Nottingham. Its 620 children speak 52 languages. Everyone in today's group arrived in Britain in the last two years. Several

¹ catkin – small flowers hanging like pieces of string from the branches of trees

² aggravated trespass – unlawfully being on private property

³ bucolic – rural, rustic

started school only two months ago. They are from Pakistan, Afghanistan, Romania and Syria, and some came from refugee camps. "You don't know what they've seen," says their teaching assistant, Yasmin Khaliq, who speaks five languages. She has been bringing groups to Wild Things for nine years. "It's a godsend," she says. "It's all outdoors, they are seeing things with their own eyes, there's no language barrier." [...]

Wild Things has worked with many migrant children who grew up in rural areas. Meanwhile British-born city children belong to a country called Indoors: they ask Kate, "What's mud?" or, "Why are there so many trees here?" It is often only in Britain that rural children from overseas are confined to city-centre flats. Their questions – "Are there elephants?" or, "Are there deadly snakes here?" – are rooted in experience of their countries of origin. For many, Kate says, the woods awaken lost memories and a yearning for home. "As soon as we light a fire, they say, 'Ah, I know this' or they point to a plant and get really animated. They are in their element."

One group last spring included a partially sighted girl. "Walking up into the woods, she stopped and said, 'Listen to that sound!'" remembers Kate. "It was the buzzing of the insects." It reminded the girl of her former country. At the end of her six weeks, she said, "I feel like I've come home." The Wild Things staff frequently hear similar declarations. "Often children can feel at home in the woods in a way they find more difficult in the community they have landed in, where technology is everything, money is everything, they are at the bottom of the pecking order⁴ and there are massive tensions in the area. In the woods they are on a level playing field. They can just be kids again." [...]

Even so, forest school teachers are acutely aware that they offer only a tiny taste of magic in childhoods where more time is spent indoors than in any preceding generation. "We help a child to fall in love with nature and we don't know if they'll ever be able to access it again," Kate says. She thinks for a moment. At least the children now know the woods are there. The place may call to them at any point in the future. "It's better to know there's a bit missing. It might be something you can use in your later life," she says. "To know that the woods can make you feel better." [...]



Sharing treasures back at camp.

Photograph: Wild Things

(773 words)

Source: Barkham, Patrick. "I feel I've come home': can forest schools help heal refugee children?" *The Guardian*. 9 May 2020. Accessed 12 Sept. 2020 from <https://www.theguardian.com/education/2020/may/09/i-feel-i-come-home-can-forest-schools-help-heal-refugee-children>.

⁴ pecking order – here: status, a social hierarchy



Zentrale schriftliche Abiturprüfung

2022

Englisch

Grundkurs

Prüfungsteil 1: Leseverstehen und Schreiben (70 %)

Aufgabenstellung 1.2

für Prüflinge

Themenschwerpunkte:	Ethnic and cultural diversity Saving the planet Aims and ambitions
Textvorlage:	'I feel I've come home': can forest schools help heal refugee children? (Auszug aus einem Artikel)

TASKS

- 1 Sum up the information about Kate Milman and her organisation "Wild Things". (30 %)
- 2 Analyze how the author's view on the project "Wild Things" is conveyed in the article, also taking into consideration the photos published with it. (30 %)
- 3 Choose one of the following tasks:
 - 3.1 "Often children can feel at home in the woods in a way they find more difficult in the community they have landed in [...]." (ll. 44/45)
Using the quote as a starting point, assess how projects like "Wild Things" can help refugee children with their integration into new social surroundings. (40 %)
 - OR
 - 3.2 For the magazine "Youth", write an article commenting on the importance of offering children opportunities to encounter nature. (40 %)